The Skeletal Merchant

Encounter design document. A short comedy encounter I wrote for my tabletop campaign, meant as a breather between heavier sessions.

OVERVIEW

While crossing the gravelands, a bleak stretch of old graves and barrows, the players meet Mortimer Boneshire, a skeleton who runs a travelling shop and treats being dead as a minor inconvenience for business. The joke is that he behaves like the most professional merchant the players have ever met, and nothing about his condition makes him reconsider any of it.

The encounter fits anywhere the players need to restock. It can be a quick trade or turn into a longer scene if the players start asking questions.

MORTIMER BONESHIRE

Mortimer wears an immaculate merchant's outfit on a bare skeleton: a fedora, a silk waistcoat and a row of gold teeth. His cart is well kept, his stock is neatly sorted, and he keeps a ledger in tidy handwriting. He whistles while he works, tips his hat to customers and counts his coins with great care.

He plays every moment completely straight. He is honest, he genuinely wants to help, he gives good advice, and he takes real offence at any suggestion that he might cheat someone. He knows he has become a little "slim" over the years, but it has never occurred to him that this might bother anyone else.

THE SCENE

The players find Mortimer at the side of the road, arranging his wares on the cart while a skeletal donkey waits patiently in its harness. The sign on the cart reads "Mortimer's Mobile Merchandise, est. 200+ years".

Players can approach carefully, walk straight up to him or try to avoid him. Most groups will assume he is a threat, and the first beat of the scene is the moment they realise he only wants to sell them something. Mortimer tips his hat, spreads both arms in welcome and greets them like valued customers.

RUNNING THE COMEDY

The humour comes from three sources, and the scene works best when the GM spreads them out instead of using everything at once.

Physical comedy. Coins fall through Mortimer's ribcage while he counts them, and items slip through his bones so that he keeps having to bend down for them. At some point the donkey loses a vertebra, which Mortimer reattaches without interrupting his sales pitch.

Irony. Mortimer sells holy water ("Excellent for cleaning!") and weapons made for destroying undead ("Quality craftsmanship, I assure you!"). He also warns the players about the dangerous undead in the area, because in his opinion they are terrible for business.

Fair prices. Players expect a lonely merchant in the wilderness to fleece them, and Mortimer charges fair prices instead. Playing against that expectation is funnier than any amount of overcharging.

PLAYER CHOICES

Mortimer has an answer ready for the obvious reactions, and each one keeps him in character.

- When players ask what he is, he says: "Oh, the slim look? A recent change of diet!"

- When they point out the irony, he says: "Business is business, living or otherwise!"
- When they ask for a discount, he says: "I run a respectable establishment!"
- When they threaten him, he says: "Violence is terrible for customer relations!"

DESIGN NOTES

The joke depends on consistency. Mortimer never acknowledges that his situation is absurd, and the GM should resist the temptation to let him wink at the players. The moment he admits it is funny, it stops being funny.

The scene earns its place in play. Mortimer is a real merchant with useful stock and honest information about the dangers ahead, so the encounter is worth something even to players who do not care about the jokes.

It leaves hooks for later. A cheerful undead shopkeeper raises questions, such as how long he has been travelling these roads and who his other customers are. The GM can pick these up in a later session or leave them alone.